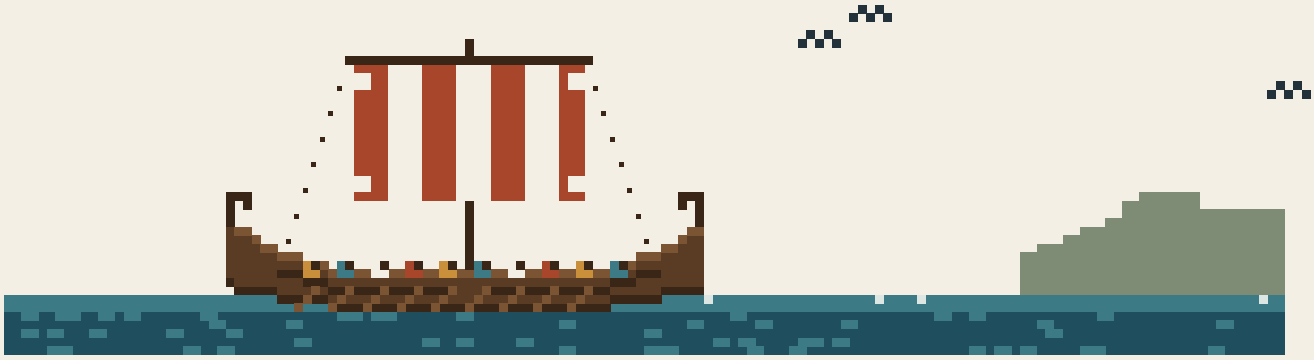
OAR AND EMBER

04 / Setting and Campaign Bible

Geography, beliefs, history, supernatural rules and chapter structure for the Narrow Sea, around AD 900.



The Narrow Sea is a few days' sailing wide and crowded with people who need each other and fear each other: Gaelic farmers and kings, monks with long memories, Norse-Gaelic traders, hungry raiders, and the old powers of sea, mist and hill that both peoples half believe in.

HOW TO USE THIS SET

Use this book for world facts, stable IDs, regions on foot, seasons, supernatural rules and chapter beats. It must not contradict Book 1. Book 5 holds people, Book 6 scenarios, Book 7 appearance, Book 8 voices, Book 9 tile plans and Book 10 every number. Every place, zone, power and chapter here has a stable ID for Book 2's content files.

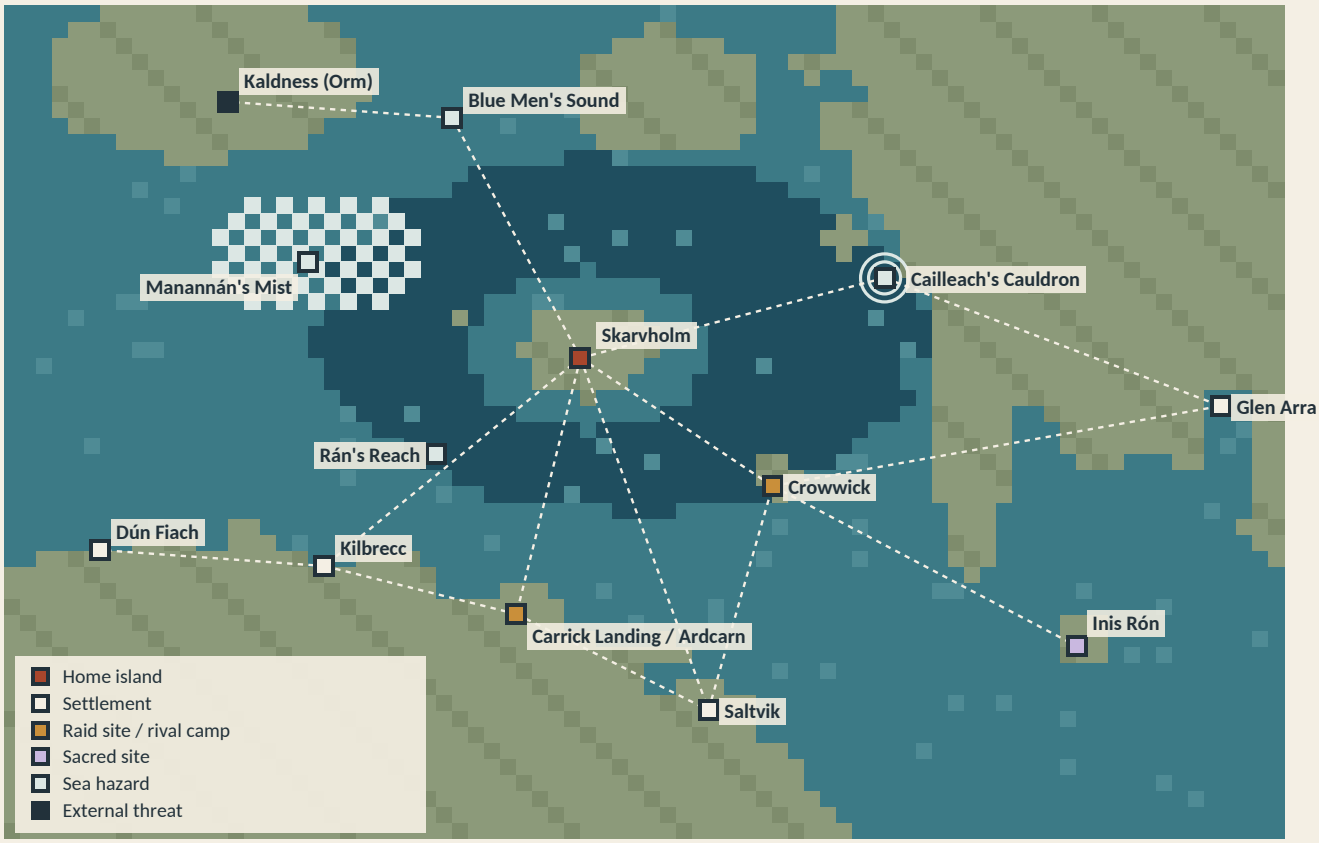
All places, people, saints and events are fictional. Mythological figures are adapted from Norse and Gaelic sources for play; they are not reconstructions of historical belief. Historical touchstones are inspiration and should be checked before any claim of accuracy is made in marketing or in-game text.

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01 / The Narrow Sea

A fictionalised North Channel between the southern Hebrides and north-east Ireland. Close enough that a good crew can cross in a day; dangerous enough that many do not.



Schematic only: a fictionalised North Channel. North is up. Irish coast lower left, Scottish coast upper right.

Shape of the region

The Irish coast runs along the south-west of the map: farmland, ringforts, a monastery on a headland and Saltvik's harbour at its eastern end. The Scottish coast closes the north-east: a long peninsula, a sea loch reaching into the hills and small islands. Skarvholm sits in the middle, exposed to every wind, a day's row from almost anywhere. To the north-west, past Blue Men's Sound, lie the northern isles where Orm Sveinsson rules from Kaldness. The deep water around Skarvholm is Rán's Reach, where the drowned go down.

Places and stable IDs

ID	Display name	Type	Who lives there	Offers the player
ISLE_SKARV	Skarvholm	Home island	The household	Shelter, steading, boatshed
SITE_CARRICK	Carrick Landing	Raid site	Ardcarn's storekeeper and guards	Grain, iron, a boat; first raid
TOWN_ARDCARN	Ardcarn	Gaelic farm settlement	About 60 people under Muiredach	Food, cattle, a holy well, grievances
ABBEY_KILBRECC	Kilbrecc	Monastery	Abbot Colmán's community and tenants	Stores, records, sanctuary, the Bell of Brecc
FORT_DUNFIACH	Dún Fiach	Ringfort and petty kingdom	King Fiachra's household and clients	Land rights, warriors, a marriage tie

ID	Display name	Type	Who lives there	Offers the player
TOWN_SALTVIK	Saltvik	Norse-Gaelic trading harbour	Merchants, shipwrights, about 400 people	Trade, refits, hired oarsmen, news
GLEN_ARRA	Glen Arra	Norse-Gaelic farmsteads	Gilla Muire's kin and herders	Cattle, archers, a sheltered loch
ISLE_INISRON	Inis Rón	Sacred island	The Keepers and the seal-kin	Lore, Manannán's favour, Nessa's past
CAMP_CROWWICK	Crowwick	Raiders' camp	Ulf Hrafnsson's crew	Rival, ally or conquest target
ISLE_KALDNESS	Kaldness	Sea king's seat	Orm Sveinsson, Heid the Grey	The external threat (late campaign)

Sea features

ID	Name	What it does
HAZ_CAULDRON	The Cailleach's Cauldron	A whirlpool tide-gate between Skarvholm and Loch Arra. Passable only near slack water; saves a day when timed well. Inspired by Corryvreckan.
HAZ_BLUEMEN	Blue Men's Sound	The shortest route north. The Blue Men rise in bad weather and challenge captains in verse (section 06).
HAZ_MIST	Manannán's Mist	A fog bank that moves by its own rules. It hides ships from pursuit and from charts. Lost crews sometimes come out somewhere else.
HAZ_RANSREACH	Rán's Reach	Deep water around Skarvholm. Storms here are fiercer; the drowned are not recovered without help.

02 / Skarvholm

A small island with a lot in it. The household lives, works and explores here for the first year and a half, and it should reward walking every day.

Size and shape

Skarvholm is 384 x 256 tiles: about a minute's run straight across, several minutes by its paths, with caves, tidal ground and interiors adding more. Thin soil, one sheltered stretch of machair, sheep gone half-wild, cliffs crowded with cormorants and a long shingle beach. Its last Gaelic family left two generations ago after a raid and a bad winter. Full tile plans are in Book 9.

Places

ID	Place	Role in play
SK_WRECK_STRAND	Wreck Strand	Opening beach. The broken ship sits on the skerry offshore; salvage and driftwood come in with storms.
SK_BROCH	The old broch	A roofless drystone tower. First shelter, later storehouse and last refuge.
SK_KELDA	Kelda Spring	The only reliable fresh water. Turns brackish at spring tides from Chapter 4: the island's clock.
SK_NAUST	Naust Cove	Sheltered landing; site of the boatshed. Slumps and silts in Chapter 5.
SK_MACHAIR	The machair	Sandy grassland: the barley plots, sheep, later a byre.
SK_HAGSEAT	The Hag's Seat	A tall stone where the Cailleach is said to rest. Runa is found here in Chapter 1.

ID	Place	Role in play
SK_CAIRN	The Hollow Cairn	A grassed mound older than anyone's story, with passages inside, a sealed inner door and, behind it, Manannán's Cup. The aos sí keep it.
SK_TIDECAVE	Seal Cave	A tide cave on the north-east cliffs where the wreck-scavengers hide their skiff.
SK_ROOKHILL	Rook Hill	Highest point. Lookout, then the watch cairn that warns of sails.
SK_GREYMEN	The Grey Men	A ring of nine stones between the hill and the bog.
SK_BOG	The peat bog	Fuel for every winter; something old lies in it.
SK_GEO	Gull Geo	A narrow hidden cove on the north-west, out of sight of Rook Hill.
SK_CELL	The hermit's cell	A ruined beehive cell above Gull Geo, burned a century ago.
SK_SKERRY	Skerry of the Drowned	A rock reached by a causeway only at spring low tides, where the drowned are seen.
SK_EAGLE	Eagle stack	A sea stack off the west cliffs with an eyrie.

Zones, resources and secrets

Zone	Terrain	Seasonal resources	Threats and secrets
ZONE_SK_STRAND	Shingle, tidal flats, skerries	Driftwood after storms; shellfish and seaweed at low tide; wreck salvage	Scavengers; Thorkel's draugr at low tide if unburied
ZONE_SK_MACHAIR	Grass, plots, the steading	Barley, kale, grazing; lambs in spring	Raiders landing on the strand
ZONE_SK_KELDA	Spring and stream	Water; watercress in spring and summer	The spring's slow failure
ZONE_SK_ROOK	Heather, high ground	Heather for thatch and bedding; hares	The lookout's blind spots
ZONE_SK_BOG	Peat bog	Peat cut in spring and summer; bog cotton	Soft ground in rain; an old offering in the peat
ZONE_SK_GREYMEN	Stone ring	None	A sunrise alignment on festival mornings
ZONE_SK_CAIRN	Mound and sheepfold	Sheep	The cairn's passages and its keepers
ZONE_SK_CLIFFS	Cliffs and eagle stack	Seabird eggs (days 10 to 40), birds in summer	Falls; the eagle
ZONE_SK_GEO	Hidden cove and cell	Kelp	A landing raiders can use unseen; the hermit's hidden niche
ZONE_SK_SEALCAVE	North-east horn and cave	Seals (pups days 65 to 85)	The tide puzzle; killing seals angers the seal-kin
ZONE_SK_HAGSEAT	West headland	Kelp, wind	The Cailleach's stone
ZONE_SK_NAUST	Cove, causeway, skerry	Fish from the rocks	The drowned on the skerry at spring low tides

Through the year

Spring brings lambs, eggs on the cliffs and the first peat cutting. Summer brings long light, birds and the best fishing. Autumn brings seal pups and storms that throw wreckage onto the strand. Winter freezes the bog pools, darkens the afternoons and brings the dead closer at Samhain and Yule.

03 / The mainland on foot

Once the household moves ashore, the new home sits in a hinterland joined by routes on foot. Some places are known; many must be found.

Candidate home sites (Chapter 6)

Site	Strengths	Weaknesses	Ways to secure it
`SITE_CARRICK_STRAND` Carrick Strand, beside Ardcarn	Good farmland, near Kilbrecc and Dún Fiach	It is the shore you first raided	Grant from Fiachra (service, hostage or a marriage tie between other households) plus compensation to Ardcarn; or seizure
`SITE_SALTNESS` Saltness headland, outside Saltvik	Trade, shipyard, strong position	Poor soil; Orm's likely first target	Purchase in silver, or a season escorting Saltvik's fleet; council vote
`SITE_ARRAFOOT` Arra Foot, mouth of Loch Arra	Sheltered water, cattle land, near Inis Rón	Remote; Crowwick next door	Protection pact with Glen Arra (deal with Ulf), or take Crowwick

How the hinterlands work

Each candidate site has a region of about nine to twelve connected scenes. Walking from the home to its farthest known place takes three to five real minutes. Known roads between waymarks can be travelled quickly when safe. Places belong to factions or to the wilderness; a hostile faction's guards attack on sight in its territory.

Carrick hinterland (`REG_CARRAIG`, Irish coast)

Place	Known at start	What it holds
Carrick Strand (home site)	Yes	Farmland by the shore you first raided
Carrick Landing and Ardcarn	Yes	Muiredach's people, their stores and their memories
Loch Carn and Brigid's well	Yes	The each-uisce, bound or loose
Coastal path to Kilbrecc	Yes	The monastery and its tenants
Ridge road to Dún Fiach	Yes	Fiachra's riders patrol it
Fiodh Dubh, the Black Wood	No	Wolves, outlaws and an old ringfort of the hill-folk with a souterrain beneath
Móin Mhór, the great bog	No	A plank road, a drowned trackway and something kept in the peat
Sliabh Carn	No	A summit cairn where Bealtaine fires are lit

Saltness hinterland (`REG_SALTNESS`, Irish coast by Saltvik)

Place	Known at start	What it holds
Saltness headland (home site)	Yes	A strong position with poor soil
Saltvik	Yes	Market, yards, guards
The salt pans and Ottar's farms	Yes	Work, trade and Ottar's stewards
The Mound Field	No	Norse burial mounds; one haugbúi guards its goods
The moor	No	Wolves in winter; peat; an old hill-fort
The river ford	Yes	The border with Dún Fiach's land

Place	Known at start	What it holds
Smugglers' cave and the sea-wife's hut	No	Contraband, wind-knots and secrets

Loch Arra hinterland (REG_ARRA, Scottish coast)

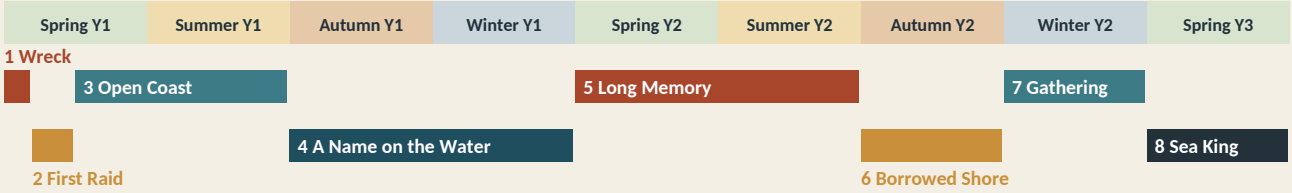
Place	Known at start	What it holds
Arra Foot (home site)	Yes	Sheltered water and cattle land
Glen Arra's steadings	Yes	Gilla Muire's kin
Coire Ard shielings	No	Summer pasture, herders and the high corrie
The pinewood	No	Boar, deer, outlaws
Beinn na Caillich	No	The Cailleach's mountain, a cave and a spring
Shore path to Crowwick	Yes	Ulf's camp across the water
Crossing to Inis Rón	No	A tidal crossing open only at spring low tides
Selkie cove and the old broch	No	Seal-kin, and a lookout Ulf uses

Wilderness rules

- Wolves hunt in packs at night and in winter; boar charge when cornered; deer and birds flush and give warning.
- Outlaws ambush roads; they can be fought, paid, avoided or recruited.
- Winter nights away from fire make the party cold; fog can turn a party round.
- Hill-folk rings and mounds have rules: leave them alone, or learn them.

04 / Seasons, weather and the calendar

A 120-day year of four 30-day seasons. Each season changes what can be done and what must be done. The calendar opens windows; it never forces an outcome on its own.



Days 1-270 (120-day years, 30-day seasons). Winter closes open-sea crossings; chapters may start early if their prerequisites are met.

The year

Days in year	Season	Sailing	Festival on the first day
1 to 30	Spring	Open crossings in fair weather; gales possible	Imbolc (from Year 2)
31 to 60	Summer	Best sailing; long light; raids and trade	Bealtaine: fires, cattle to summer grazing
61 to 90	Autumn	Harvest; storms rising; crossings riskier	Lúnasa: harvest fair at Saltvik
91 to 120	Winter	Open crossings closed except in calm windows; coastal hops only	Samhain and the Norse Winter Nights

Yule falls on day 105 of each year. Festivals are social events at home and abroad, and the nights when bargains and boundaries matter most. Samhain is when the dead and the hill-folk walk closest; Bealtaine is when bargains are easiest to strike.

What each season demands

Season	Fields	Livestock	Sea and shore	Fuel	People
Spring	Sow barley and oats by day 25 (later sowing yields less)	Lambing and calving; milk returns	Eggs on the cliffs, shellfish; crossings open	Cut peat early so it dries for 20 days	The hungry gap: stores lowest before new food; gales
Summer	Weed; cut and dry hay	Cattle to the shielings on the mainland; shearing	Best fishing; raids and fairs	Stack dry peat	Long light until 23:00; building weather
Autumn	Harvest days 61 to 75; rots after day 80	Slaughter and salt what cannot be wintered	Seal pups; storms throw wreckage ashore; fishing falls	Fill the stacks	Sickness rises; storms close in
Winter	Nothing grows	Cattle in the byre on hay; sheep on the machair	Open sea closed except calm windows; fishing on calm days only	Every heated house burns peat daily	Cold, hunger, long nights (dark 16:00 to 08:30), the dead at Samhain and Yule

Consequences that bite

Unsown plots yield nothing. Unharvested barley rots. Fresh fish spoils in two days unless dried, smoked or salted. Cattle without hay or a byre lose condition and die. A house without fuel in winter makes its residents cold, slower to heal and prone to sickness. A household that prepared well has a warm winter of crafting, stories, feasts and repairs; one that did not spends it rationing and burying. Book 10 gives the numbers and the targets for a well-prepared household at day 90.

Weather and sea

- **Wind** is a daily state with a direction and strength, forecast a day ahead by weather-wise crew. Fair wind speeds sailing; foul wind means rowing, which drains stamina and stores.
- **Tide** runs on a simple two-state-per-watch cycle (flood and ebb, with slack at the turn). Tide gates, landings and the Cauldron depend on it. Spring tides peak twice a season.
- **Visibility** is clear, haze, fog or night. Fog hides both you and others; Manannán's Mist is a special moving fog.
- **The Cailleach's washing**: one storm between days 86 and 94 of each year marks winter's arrival. After it, the sea map shows open crossings as closed except during forecast calm windows of one to three days.

05 / Beliefs

Belief is personal, mixed and practical. Nobody in the Narrow Sea belongs to a faction called "pagan" or "Celtic". People pray to what has helped them.

The Norse households

The old gods are honoured with oaths, feasts and offerings: Thor for weather and strength, Odin by those who seek wisdom or victory, Freyr for harvest, Njörd for fair sailing. Rán is feared rather than worshipped; sailors carry a little gold so that if they drown they come to her hall with a gift. Some Norse at Saltvik are baptised, often for trade, and many keep both a cross and a hammer. Oaths, reputation and a good death matter. Burial varies: mounds, stone ship-settings, boats burned or buried.

The Gaelic communities

Ardcarn, Dún Fiach and the tenants of Kilbrecc are Christian. They keep saints' days, pray at holy wells and fear the judgement of the Church. They also keep older customs without contradiction in their own eyes: fires at Bealtaine, care at Samhain, respect for the good people of the mounds, and the cross of rushes on Brigid's day. Kings take hostages, keep poets and make alliances by fosterage and marriage.

The Norse-Gaelic world

Saltvik and Glen Arra are mixed: Norse names with Gaelic mothers, Gaelic names with Norse ships. In Glen Arra the smith casts crosses and hammers in the same mould and sees nothing strange in it. These people translate between the others, and profit from it.

The Keepers of Inis Rón (fantasy element)

A small community on a seal island who still serve the old powers openly: Manannán, the Cailleach and the seal-kin. They are a deliberate fantasy element, not a claim that such communities existed. They remember the compact that once kept Rán out of these waters. Some are seal-kin themselves, able to put on a seal's skin.

How belief appears in play

- Each resident has a **Faith** value pointing at something specific: the old gods, Christ and the saints, the land-spirits, or nothing.
- The steading's shrine is chosen by the residents, not the player alone. A hammer-post, a cross, a stone for offerings or more than one can stand together.
- Sacred places raise the stakes of raids. Taking a relic, a well's offerings or a mound's grave goods triggers both human and supernatural consequences.
- The game shows sincere believers in every tradition, including sceptics and hypocrites. It never declares one tradition correct.

Historical touchstones (inspiration only)

Norse raids on Irish and Hebridean monasteries are recorded from the 790s. A Norse base at Dublin is recorded from 841, and its Norse rulers were expelled in 902 before returning in 917. Irish annals name the Gall-Gaedil, the mixed Norse-Gaelic people, from the 850s. The Corryvreckan whirlpool and its Cailleach lore inspire the Cauldron. Treat these as atmosphere; Saltvik, Kilbrecc and every named person are invented.

06 / History

Every faction tells this history differently. The table records what actually happened in the game world; Book 5 records who believes what.

When	Event (world truth)	Who tells it differently
Time out of mind	The cairn-builders raise the Hollow Cairn. The aos sí withdraw into the hills. Manannán's mist guards the Narrow Sea under a compact with the people of the coast.	The Keepers tell it as sacred history; monks call the hill-folk fallen angels or the old dead.
About 300 years ago	The prince Breccán drowns in the Cauldron with fifty men. His brother, later Saint Brecc, founds Kilbrecc and makes the Bell. Rung over the Cauldron each Lúnasa, it keeps Breccán's drowned crew asleep.	Monks: the saint's prayer stilled the water. Keepers: the saint struck a bargain with Rán in a saint's name.
About 100 years ago	The first Norse ships. Kilbrecc is raided twice; its tower is built. Skarvholm's hermit cell is burned.	Kilbrecc's annals record the raids precisely and remember the sails.
About 60 years ago	A Norse winter camp becomes Saltvik. Trade begins to outweigh raiding.	Saltvik says it was founded by agreement; Dún Fiach says by theft.
About 30 years ago	Norse-Gaelic families settle Glen Arra. Dún Fiach and Saltvik fight, then make peace through a marriage.	Both sides claim to have won.
About 12 years ago	Orm Sveinsson survives a wreck no one else survived. The seeress Heid the Grey becomes his adviser.	Orm says Rán spared him for greatness. Heid knows the price.
1 to 5 years ago	Orm takes independent harbours in the northern isles, demanding tribute and hostages. His fleet never seems to meet a storm.	Northern exiles talk of fog that comes when Orm wants it.
This spring	Orm's ships burn Hvitness. Chief Thorkel Ketilsson flees south with his household in an old ship. A mist hides them from pursuit and then wrecks them on Skarvholm. Thorkel drowns.	Was the mist Heid's or Manannán's? The answer matters in Chapter 7.

Orm's bargain (world truth, revealed in Chapters 5 to 7)

Orm promised Rán the drowned of the Narrow Sea in return for command of tides and fog through Heid. Every ship he sinks feeds the bargain. The rising tides at Skarvholm are Rán's reach growing as her share grows. Breaking the bargain requires three things, in any order, discovered through play: renewing Manannán's compact at Inis Rón (which needs Manannán's Cup from the Hollow Cairn on Skarvholm), ringing the Bell of Brecc over the Cauldron at slack water to release Breccán's crew, and taking Heid's staff from her or persuading her to break it. Partial success weakens Orm's weather in the finale; full success removes it.

07 / Supernatural rules

The supernatural is real in the fiction, rare in practice and fair in its rules. It draws on Norse and Gaelic myth and it keeps its bargains.

The world-truth model

Every supernatural actor has a **true state** in the save: what it is, what it wants, what it has agreed and what binds it. Testimony, rumour and belief can differ from that truth. The player learns the truth through signs, objects, witnesses and experiment. The code never rewrites the truth to suit a scene.

Fairness contract

Every dangerous supernatural mechanic has four parts:

1. **A visible sign** before danger: sound, tracks, animal behaviour, weather, an object out of place.
2. **A learnable rule** that a careful player can work out or be told.
3. **A player response** that changes the outcome: avoid, bargain, perform a specific act, fight for time, or withdraw.
4. **A saved consequence** that persists and is reported.

No instant death from an invisible knowledge check. Ordinary weapons can buy time against some threats; not every encounter is a combat check. Rituals are specific acts with discovered information, witnesses or objects, never a universal spell bar. Powers keep the stated terms of accepted bargains; disputes arise over scope, interpretation or who had authority to promise.

Rán and her daughters (Norse)

Rán gathers the drowned in her net. Her nine daughters are the waves, and the worst storms carry their names: **Kólga** the cold wave, **Hrönn** the grasping wave, **Blóðughadda** whose foam is red. Through Orm's bargain her reach is growing.

- **Signs:** tides higher than the moon allows, gulls flying low and silent, sea-light (pale green under the water at night), the drowned seen standing in the shallows.
- **Rules:** she claims those who drown; gold carried aboard buys a drowned crew member a gentle welcome. She cannot take what is above the tide line on land she has not been given.
- **In play:** named storms on the sea map; the Kelda spring turning brackish; a drowned crewmate's body unrecoverable from Rán's Reach without a bargain.
- **The drowned at the feast:** if a crew member drowns and their rites are honoured, they may appear dripping at the funeral feast and leave in peace: a sign Rán received them well. This is an omen, not a horror.

Manannán mac Lir and the mist (Gaelic)

The lord of the sea between Ireland and Britain, who hides what he favours in his cloak of mist. He rarely appears directly. When he does it is as **the Ferryman**: a grey-cloaked stranger in a small boat who offers to guide a ship through fog for a price.

- **Signs:** fog that moves against the wind; the sound of hooves on water; a figure who is never quite closer.
- **Rules:** he asks for a true story, a gift given freely, or a promise of hospitality to strangers. He never asks for blood. He keeps his word exactly and expects the same.
- **Offering:** a bundle of green rushes at midsummer, laid on the water at Inis Rón.
- **Manannán's Cup:** in Irish tales, a cup that breaks at three lies and mends at three truths. The cairn-builders laid it in the Hollow Cairn when the compact was sworn. It leaves its stone only after three true things the speaker

would rather not say are spoken at the Door of Three Truths; each lie wakes a warden, and three lies seal the Door until the next spring tide. Lifting it draws Rán's tide over the island.

- **In play:** the moving `HAZ_MIST`; shortcuts and escapes; renewing his compact in Chapter 7 can cover the alliance fleet in the finale.

The Cailleach (Gaelic)

The old woman of winter and storms, who washes her plaid in the Cauldron before winter comes.

- **Signs:** a hag-shaped cloud over the Cauldron; hail out of season; the Hag's Seat stone wet when nothing else is.
- **Rules:** she respects endurance and plain speaking. She will sell a calm window in winter for something that cost you effort: a season's first catch, a hard-won tool, an honest confession.
- **In play:** the Cailleach's washing (winter's arrival); weather bargains; her stone on Skarvholm helps Runa in Chapter 1 if the player leaves an offering.

The Blue Men (Scottish)

Blue-skinned storm kelpies who rise in Blue Men's Sound and challenge a ship's captain with two lines of verse. If the captain completes the verse well, they let the ship pass. If the captain hesitates or answers badly, they try to swamp it.

- **Signs:** blue shapes in the troughs; the sea suddenly too loud; a voice speaking verse from the water.
- **Rules:** they reward wit and boldness. Silence counts as failure; a bold, fitting answer counts as success even if it is not clever.
- **In play:** a short dialogue duel with three to four choices per line. Crew with the right skills suggest answers. Failure means a storm scene with damage, not instant sinking.

Land-spirits and the hill-folk (Norse and Gaelic)

Norse settlers speak of **landvættir**, the spirits of a land; Gaels speak of the **aos sí**, the good people of the mounds. In the game they are the same kind of power seen through two traditions: local, territorial and touchy about respect.

- **Rule of the stem:** a carved beast-head on the prow frightens the land-spirits of a shore. Unship it before landing where you want to be welcome. Leave it up to intimidate.
- **Rules:** they keep boundaries, demand hospitality and remember insult. Their gifts can be safe. Their beauty does not mean kindness and their strangeness does not mean malice.
- **In play:** the Hollow Cairn on Skarvholm (whose occupant can be a neighbour, a nuisance or a protector), shrines that protect villages, and boundaries that matter when choosing a mainland site.

The unquiet dead (Norse)

Death is normally final. A **draugr** rises only from a specific unresolved condition: a body left unburied, an oath broken over a corpse, a death under protection betrayed, or a deliberate raising. A **haugbúi** guards its mound and its goods.

- Each has an identity, an anchor, a behaviour and at least one discoverable resolution.
- Violence can drive one off for a night; only resolving the anchor ends it.
- A named dead resident never returns as an ordinary enemy.
- **Thorkel's anchor:** if Bran's protection of the body fails and the player does not give Thorkel rites, he walks Wreck Strand at low tide from Chapter 3, wanting what he died owing: vengeance on Orm, or a promise that his household will be safe.
- **Breccán's crew:** fifty drowned men under the Cauldron, kept asleep by the Bell. Take the Bell and they follow it.

Omens (Norse and Gaelic)

- **The fetch and the fylgja:** a resident's double, or an animal that follows them, is seen by another resident. It means that person is close to death. Rest, care or keeping them off the next voyage can change it. The game never kills someone because their fetch appeared; it is a warning.
- **The washer at the ford:** before the final battle, a woman is seen washing bloody shirts in a stream. Asked, she will name whose shirts they are. The player can change orders, and so change fate.
- **The bean sí:** the keening woman of Dún Fiach's royal line. When she is heard, someone of Fiachra's blood will die unless something is done.

Creatures of the sea and water

- **The each-uisce:** a water-horse in Loch Carn above Ardcarn, bound by Brigid's well. It offers a fine horse to ride and drags riders under. Raiding the well's offerings releases it. Binding it again is a redemption path with Ardcarn.
- **Selkies:** seal-kin who take off their skins to walk ashore. A stolen skin binds a selkie to whoever holds it. Nessa's story turns on one.
- **The lyngbakr:** a heather-backed beast so large it is mistaken for an island. Sign: an uncharted island with no birds and a sweet smell. Rule: do not land. Response: steer off, or throw food to draw it under. Consequence of landing: an escape scene as the island sinks.
- **The Long Swimmer:** a serpent shape that follows ships for days. It wants something aboard. Learning what (a stolen object, a drowned body, a debt) resolves it without a fight.

Human practitioners

- **Heid the Grey:** Orm's seeress, a völva who works seiðr with staff and song. She speaks for Rán and can call fog and turn tides within Orm's bargain. She is a person with history and doubts, and can be argued with (Book 5).
- **Sea-wives and wind-knots:** a sea-wife at Saltvik sells cords tied in three knots. One knot loosed is a fair wind, two a strong one, three a gale nobody controls. Each knot also adds a little to Rán's share.
- **The Keepers:** they know the old compacts and the right words, and can teach specific rites. They are not wizards.

Blood on sacred ground

Killing at a holy well, a church, a mound or a stone ring is noticed by more than people. The place's power responds according to its rules: Brigid's well clouds and the each-uisce stirs; the Hollow Cairn's keepers withdraw their goodwill; a church becomes a place where the household's dead do not rest easily. These are consequences with signs and remedies, not curses without escape.

Christian relics

The **Bell of Brecc** stills water around it and keeps Breccán's crew asleep. Whether this is the saint's holiness or an old bargain dressed in a saint's name is never settled; both readings fit the evidence. Relics have real, bounded effects in the fiction and are treated with the weight their keepers give them.

Prohibited patterns

- No universal mana, spell bar or resurrection.
- No supernatural damage through unseen terrain or without a tell.
- No monster in every voyage. Target: a supernatural event every third or fourth voyage on average, with signs more often than encounters.
- No power that changes the terms of an accepted bargain after the fact.

08 / Chapter structure

Eight chapters across six phases. Each chapter has a window, a goal, key beats, unlocks and a gate. Beats are ordered by default but most can be taken in a different order.

Chapter 1: The Wreck

Window: days 1 to 6. **Session target:** 45 to 60 minutes. **Goal:** shelter, rescue four crew, make the boat seaworthy.

1. Wake on Wreck Strand. Control in seconds. Hild is calling beyond the rocks; carry her above the tide line.
2. Hild leads to the old broch. Gather driftwood, light a fire, treat her injury. Warmth, food, a conversation.
3. Three searches, any order: **Oddi** injured near the wreck (recover a chest now, or take Oddi home first); **Bran** in a sheepfold by the Hollow Cairn, guarding Thorkel's body from three wreck-scavengers (fight, sneak, or bargain with the chest); **Runa** at the Hag's Seat, injured, following a strange light (leave an offering for the Cailleach's help, or take the slower cliff path).
4. Three repairs: patch the hull with salvaged boards; recover rigging from the wreck section on the skerry at low tide; recover the steering oar from the scavengers' skiff in Seal Cave (fight, steal, trade, or have Runa carve a new one over two days).
5. One reversible customisation: more cargo space, or a raised fighting position at the bow.
6. Thorkel's rites (optional, recommended by Hild): a stone ship-setting on the machair, or a sea burial with gold for Rán.
7. Days and nights pass in real time: the first night by the fire, the first dawn report, the first fish from the shore.
8. Launch. Name the boat and choose a sail mark. The sea map reveals the coast and smoke rising at Carrick Landing.

Unlocks: sea map, steading basics. **Gate:** the boat is launched.

Chapter 2: The First Raid

Window: days 7 to 15. **Goal:** provisions and iron. Full scenario in Book 6. Lead from a chart fragment and the smoke. One preparation advantage. Carrick Landing supports theft, bargaining, threatening the keeper or fighting the guards, with one complication. The boat cannot hold everything. Return to Skarvholm: the haul becomes tangible (a forge, food runway, a newcomer at the fire). Two leads are offered: Saltvik (trade and Runa's sister) and Glen Arra (cattle and a rumour of Ulf). Back home, the first days of real work: the forge, the drying racks, the first peat cutting and the first plots dug.

Unlocks: raiding, home consequences, homestead tasks and building designation, the steward role if Eithne joined. **Gate:** two leads offered.

Chapter 3: The Open Coast

Window: days 16 to 60. **Goal:** learn the coast, build a capable crew, make the island a home.

- Saltvik: trade, the first ship fittings, Kolbeinn the smith, wind-knots, news of Orm.
- Glen Arra and Crowwick: Ulf appears as a rival who wants a share of everything.
- Kilbrecc can be visited, traded with or raided. Brother Senán can become a contact.
- The fog-light event brings Nessa (Book 6).
- About day 40 to 50, the **Followers' boat** arrives: Old Gudrun and five more of Thorkel's household who escaped separately. Too many mouths; the island needs more.
- At home: sow the plots before day 25, cut peat, build the longhouse, and explore the whole island: Seal Cave, the Grey Men, the cairn, the cell and the Skerry of the Drowned.

- First sign of the tides: a spring tide reaches the broch's foot.

Gate: residents at least 9 and a longhouse built, or day 60.

Chapter 4: A Name on the Water

Window: days 61 to 120. **Goal:** become wealthy and survive winter.

- Bigger targets: the Bell of Brecc, Glen Arra's cattle, Asgrim's tribute ship. Rival crews notice.
- The karvi hull: bought at Saltvik, captured, or built in the boatshed over winter.
- **Asgrim Cold-Hand** arrives from Orm: a tenth of all plunder and one hostage, or Orm's displeasure.
- At home: harvest between days 61 and 75, cut and dry hay, slaughter and salt, fill the peat stacks and lay the ship up in the boatshed. The Year 1 threat schedule (Book 10) tests the watch.
- The Cailleach's washing closes the sea. Winter at home: cold, fuel and sickness; Samhain and the Yule feast; stories, crafting and repairs; the Nessa reveal window opens.
- The Kelda spring turns brackish at spring tides.

Gate: Asgrim returns at the end of winter for an answer.

Chapter 5: The Long Memory

Window: days 121 to 180. **Goal:** face the cost of earlier raids and decide the household's future.

- Retaliation falls due according to the deed ledger: Fergal's ships from Dún Fiach, an interdict from Kilbrecc, Ulf's ambition, Ardcarn's hired swords. None is scripted; each is earned.
- Orm's fleet takes an independent harbour. Refugees arrive.
- A storm-tide slumps Naust Cove. The spring fails at every spring tide.
- **The household council:** stay and dwindle, or move ashore. Residents argue from their values.

Gate: the household commits to a mainland site. Choosing to stay leads to the Lonely Isle path.

Chapter 6: The Borrowed Shore

Window: days 181 to 210 (earlier if the council commits earlier). **Goal:** secure a mainland home and move the household.

- Secure the chosen site by purchase, service, marriage tie, protection pact or conquest.
- Move people, livestock, stores and workshops over several voyages. The consort ship helps.
- Explore the hinterland on foot: known places, places still to be found, the wilderness and hostile ground.
- Raise a hall and a palisade. Meet the neighbours who remember you.
- Decide what remains on Skarvholm: an outpost with a few residents, a lookout only, or nothing. Whatever is left there is taken when Orm seizes the island in Chapter 7.

Gate: hall and defences built and most of the household moved.

Chapter 7: The Gathering

Window: days 211 to 240. **Goal:** unite former rivals against Orm.

- A council under sanctuary at Kilbrecc. Each faction states its contribution and its demand.
- Compensation, returned captives, returned relics, public concessions and marriage ties are negotiated.
- Rival raiders call it betrayal. Some leave; some can be won.
- Orm's ships take Skarvholm (about day 228); outpost residents become captives in the broch.
- The Keepers reveal how Orm's bargain can be broken, and that the compact needs Manannán's Cup from the Hollow Cairn, where Gróa is now digging. Nessa's fate is settled.

Gate: the council ends and Orm's fleet sails at the start of Year 3.

Chapter 8: The Sea King

Window: days 241 to 270. **Goal:** defeat or outlast Orm and break his bargain.

- **The Return to Skarvholm (days 241 to 252):** a required expedition to the occupied island for the Cup (Book 6 scenario 9). Checkpoint before landing; one retry before day 255 if it fails.
- A last preparation window: renew the compact at Inis Rón if the Cup is in hand; assign allies, ships and defenders. Checkpoint before the battle.
- The washer at the ford names who will die. Orders can change it.
- Battle in two linked parts: a sea engagement at the approaches (Rán's daughters against Manannán's mist, if renewed) and the defence of the mainland home.
- Breaking the bargain during the battle turns the weather. Orm can be killed, captured, exiled or bargained with.

Endings: the United Coast, the Uneasy Peace, the New Sea King, the Lonely Isle; defeat returns to the pre-battle checkpoint.

Chapter state contract

Each chapter has states: **locked**, **open**, **active**, **resolved**. A chapter opens when its window starts or its prerequisites are met, whichever is later. Resolution is recorded with the facts that caused it. Loading a save never replays a resolved beat.